MANDAR DEODHAR



TAMING THE PROBLEM

How to balance compassion, cleanliness and ecological health

- **Allow limited feeding hours or designated zones to respect faith, while protecting public health**
- **Run civic awareness campaigns on the health and ecological risks of overfeeding instead of relying only on fines**
- **Act against unauthorised *kabutarkhanas* that fuel unchecked pigeon growth**
- **Frame policy on ecology and scientific evidence, not sentiment**
- **Cut food surplus so pigeons forage naturally and predators like kites and cats thrive**

CLIPPED WINGS BMC shuts down *kabutarkhana* at Dadar after court orders, Aug. 11

restrictions. Pune fines offenders. In Mysuru, BJP MP Yaduveer Krishnadatta Chamaraja Wadiyar persuaded Jains to stop feeding birds near the city's palace, citing risks to both health and heritage. Globally, the response is similar: feeding is regulated in New York and London, and fined in Singapore.

SCIENCE VS SENTIMENT

What began as a routine civic crackdown in Mumbai soon spiralled into a full-blown clash over health, religion and identity. Shiv Sena MLC Manisha Kayande, who raised the matter in the legislative council, argued that an issue of scientific and medical importance had been turned into an emotional one. A former professor of zoology, she described pigeons as "flying rodents" responsible for spreading zoonotic diseases (see *Avian Ailments*). The myofibrils (protein filaments) on their bodies, she explains, often find their way into human lungs and trigger respiratory disorders. Such risks, she notes, have prompted countries worldwide to control pigeon populations. In the past, she adds, even grocery shops encouraged informal feeding spots for commercial gain.

Petitioners contest that view. Sneha Visaria, one of them, claims that no scientific study directly links pigeon exposure to respiratory ailments. "They are not ready to understand that these are rarest of rare cases that do not happen in an open environment," she says, pointing out that for eight months, the civic body has been cracking down on *kabutarkhanas* in Khar, Gowalia Tank, Naigaon and Lalbag. Instead of bans, she urges that feeders be permitted to offer grain in three one-hour blocks across the day. A trustee of the Dadar Kabutarkhana Trust adds that the ban has led to "thousands of pigeons dying due to hunger and thirst". Similarly, Atul Shah (Dadhi), trustee of Jain organisation Vardhaman Parivar, says any ban on feeding would infringe on the fundamental rights of birds, who "have their own niche in the ecosystem". He cites RTI replies from civic-run hospitals that appeared to downplay the scale of the threat: between July 2024 and July 2025, Sion Hospital recorded 12 cases of hypersensitivity pneumonitis, of which just four patients had been exposed to pigeons; KEM Hospital had eight cases, with two linked to the birds.

> **"An issue of scientific importance has been turned into an emotional one... health risks have prompted countries worldwide to control pigeon populations"**
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> **Manisha Kayande,** *MLC, Shiv Sena*

Doctors disagree. Dr Deepak Bhanushali, a pulmonologist at state-run JJ Hospital, says his team sees two to three new cases each month of hypersensitivity pneumonitis caused by exposure to pigeon feathers or droppings. "Though there are no tests to prove that it is caused only by pigeons, exposure to pigeons is among the most common causes," he explains. The disease's progression can be slowed, he adds, but not reversed. Lung transplants, too, are rare and only about half of them succeed. "Such diseases should be prevented rather than faced," he warns. Voices of reason have emerged within the Jain community too. Dr Kalyan Gangwal, a senior physician from Pune who describes himself as a "staunch Jain", advises against pigeon-feeding in thickly populated areas because of the health risks involved. He says easy availability of food has eroded the birds'